

Delhi Public Library vs Toronto Public Library

IFLA-aligned comparator report using an NCT service-area baseline

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Core finding. On IFLA's standard public-library metric frame, Delhi Public Library is not merely smaller than Toronto Public Library. It is operating at a different order of public reach. Using the NCT service-area denominator of 19.0 million residents, DPL records about **14,461 annual book issues per million residents**. TPL records about **9.33 million borrowings per million residents**. That is a **645x per-capita use gap**.

Denominator

The primary denominator is **NCT of Delhi**, not the full National Capital Region. DPL is treated as a Delhi service-area institution; comparing it to the full NCR would charge it for a wider regional population it does not formally cover. NCR is still useful as a latent-demand sensitivity, because readers and workers cross the NCT boundary, but it is not the headline denominator.

The old 2011-only denominator is not used for the main comparison. SevenT4 now uses the [theright2read](#) population correction source: `STATE_POP_MN["Delhi"] = 19`, which cites the MoHFW Technical Group population projections for 2011-2036. The exact annual Delhi row should still be promoted when the source PDF is reachable; the MoHFW server timed out during this session.

Area	Population used	Role
NCT of Delhi	19,000,000	Primary DPL service-area denominator
City of Toronto	3,000,000	Primary TPL service-area denominator
NCR sensitivity	27,000,000-32,000,000	Latent-demand sensitivity only

IFLA Frame

This report uses the IFLA Library Map of the World metric frame: service points, registered users, physical visits, physical loans, eBook loans, audio-book loans, downloads, staff, volunteers, and libraries with internet access. The comparison below uses only fields that are currently captured from source reports. Missing IFLA fields are listed as data gaps rather than inferred.

IFLA-aligned metric	DPL, NCT baseline	TPL, city baseline	Reading
Conservative service points per 1M	2.1	34.0	TPL has 16.2x the service-point density.
Inclusive DPL touch-points per 1M	8.6	34.0	Even counting DPL mobile stops and reading centres, TPL is 4.0x denser.
Registered users per 1M	5,818	Not published in current TPL source	DPL has about one registered member per 172 NCT residents.
New card registrations per 1M	Not comparable	78,423	TPL reports new registrations, not total registered users.
Physical loans / borrowings per 1M	14,461	9,333,333	TPL is 645x higher per resident.
Physical visits proxy per 1M	17,646	4,466,667	DPL reports reading-room attendance, not all visits; TPL is 253x higher.
Collection items per 1M	80,396	3,500,000	TPL has 43.5x the collection density.
Annual additions per 1M	164	Not captured	DPL collection refresh is only 0.20%.

The most important warning is not simply that DPL has fewer outlets. It is that use is extremely low relative to both population and collection stock. DPL records **0.18 annual issues per collection item**. TPL records about **2.67 borrowings per collection item**. That is a 14.8x stock-turnover gap.

Finance

PPP conversion uses the World Bank [PA.NUS.PPP](#) indicator: India 2024 at 20.4219876045922 INR per international dollar, and Canada 2025 at 1.147294 CAD per international dollar.

Finance metric	DPL	TPL
Operating expenditure, PPP	\$16.11m intl.	\$258.05m intl.
Operating spend per resident, PPP	\$0.85	\$86.02
Spend per loan / borrowing, PPP	\$58.63	\$9.22
Materials expenditure, PPP	\$0.086m intl.	\$20.12m intl.
Materials spend per resident, PPP	\$0.0045	\$6.71
Materials share of expenditure	0.53%	7.80%

The finance interpretation is straightforward:

- TPL operates at 16.0x DPL's PPP expenditure scale.
- TPL spends 101.5x more per resident.
- DPL's low captured use makes spend per loan high despite low total funding.

- TPL's materials spending is over 230x DPL's PPP materials line and 1,481x higher per resident.
- DPL is not renewing or circulating stock at TPL-like intensity.

DPL's 2023-24 inflow is almost entirely grant-funded: grant receipts are 97.99% of grant plus other income, while other income is 2.01%. That is not a problem by itself; public libraries are public goods. The problem is that the public subsidy is not translating into visible public use.

DPL also ended 2023-24 with **INR 4.78 crore** in closing unspent balance. That is **14.5% of annual expenditure** and **27.2x the annual books and reading materials expense**. In a network with 49.6% staff vacancy and a 0.20% collection refresh rate, the unspent balance is operationally important.

DPL Timeline

Year	Members	Issues	Reading-room attendance	Collection	Books added
2009-10	64,883	1,039,977	316,657	Not parsed	77,872
2010-11	73,467	1,169,734	244,499	Not parsed	33,868
2018-19	187,138	814,858	365,854	1,694,950	27,958
2019-20	189,235	477,008	353,246	1,596,125	13,310
2021-22	156,867	196,889	132,411	1,605,443	2,697
2023-24	110,534	274,751	335,270	1,527,531	3,108

The trend is severe. Membership falls from 189,235 in 2019-20 to 110,534 in 2023-24, a 41.6% decline. Annual issues fall from 1.17 million in 2010-11 to 274,751 in 2023-24, a 76.5% decline. Books added fall from 77,872 in 2009-10 to 3,108 in 2023-24, a 96.0% decline.

Reading-room attendance is the one partial recovery signal: 2023-24 attendance is back near the 2017-18 to 2019-20 range. But reading-room recovery does not offset the collapse in issue activity and stock renewal.

NCR Sensitivity

If the full NCR population range of 27-32 million is used as a shadow catchment, the DPL position worsens. This is not the primary comparison, but it matters for latent reading demand.

Catchment sensitivity	Population	Service points per 1M	Issues per 1M	Reading-room attendance per 1M	PPP spend per resident
NCR low	27,000,000	1.48	10,176	12,417	\$0.60
NCR high	32,000,000	1.25	8,586	10,477	\$0.50

The NCT denominator is therefore the conservative baseline. It does not make DPL look worse; it makes the comparison administratively fair.

Data Gaps

DPL reporting now covers many core operational fields, but several IFLA metrics are still missing or incomplete:

- all physical visits, not only reading-room attendance;
- eBook loans;
- audio-book loans;
- downloads;
- libraries with internet access;
- full-time staff in IFLA-compatible form;
- volunteers;

- digital sessions, public computers, Wi-Fi sessions, and programme attendance.

TPL's current public pages expose richer digital, programme, and branch-visit data, but do not expose total registered users in the same way DPL reports membership. The report therefore compares TPL new card registrations separately and does not pretend they are equivalent to DPL registered-member stock.

Working Conclusions

1. DPL should be compared on NCT, not NCR, for the main service-area baseline.
2. Even on the conservative NCT denominator, DPL's service density, borrowing, collection density, materials spending, and collection renewal are far below Toronto's.
3. DPL's current problem is both under-resourcing and low conversion of existing stock into public use.
4. Grant dependence is normal for a public library. The red flag is that 98% grant-funded operations produce extremely low per-capita use and very low materials renewal.
5. The next Delhi extraction should prioritize full DPL annual reports, branch locations, service hours, digital services, programmes, and staff deployment by branch so the IFLA frame can be completed.

Source Base

- Delhi Public Library annual reports page: <https://dpl.gov.in/index.php/annual-reports>
- Delhi Public Library Annual Report 2023-24: https://drive.google.com/file/d/1d6K6glvU5osL5ck9tR_2LLuoHFQUeh0e/view?usp=sharing
- Toronto Public Library, About the Library: <https://tpl.ca/about-the-library/>
- Toronto Public Library, Library Finance: <https://tpl.ca/about-the-library/library-finance/>
- Toronto Public Library, Open Data: <https://tpl.ca/about-the-library/open-data/>
- IFLA Library Map of the World, Data Lab: <https://librarymap.ifla.org/datalab>
- IFLA Library Map of the World, About Library Data: <https://librarymap.ifla.org/about-library-data>
- IFLA-UNESCO Public Library Manifesto 2022: <https://www.ifla.org/publications/ifla-unesco-public-library-manifesto-2022/>
- World Bank PPP conversion factor, GDP, PA.NUS.PPP: https://api.worldbank.org/v2/country/IND;CAN/indicator/PA.NUS.PPP?format=json&per_page=100
- Local SevenT4 derived tables: [data/comparators/delhi_toronto/library_comparison_metrics.csv](#), [data/comparators/delhi_toronto/library_comparison_summary.json](#)